Interviewer guide: Years 7 to 10

This guide is reusable. Nothing is written on it: keep one in the room, in a folder or laminated. Ratings and notes for each student go on the **Interview sheet** (`forms/Interview_Sheet_Y7_Y10`).

About 15 minutes, 1:1. The interview is held **in English**. It has three jobs: to hear the student's spoken English (the speaking band), to get to know the student (interests, learning, wellbeing, **future plans and aspirations**), and to judge their **suitability** for the international programme. It opens with the Graded Sentence Reading Screen (3 to 5 minutes; start Level 6 for Year 7, 7 for Year 8, 8 for Year 9, 9 for Year 10; follow `shared/Sentence_Reading_Guide` and write the points on the Reading front sheet, `forms/Reading_Front_Sheet`).

How to ask. Start with the main question. If the student struggles, use the **easier** prompt (a yes or no, or a choice). If they answer easily, use the **stretch** prompt. This lets every student show their best English. Wait at least five seconds before rephrasing. Answers must be in English.

Pace of speech. Speak at a steady, clear pace: about 160 to 185 words a minute (Year 7 about 160, Year 8 about 160, Year 9 about 175, Year 10 about 185). Use the same pace for every candidate in the year group, and use it for the instructions and meaning questions of the sentence reading too. Do not rush: wait at least five seconds before rephrasing.

Safeguarding. Keep the door open or another adult present. If a student tells you something that worries you about their safety or wellbeing, do not promise to keep it secret; listen, write down their words, and pass it to the Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day.

1. Questions (10 minutes)

Choose about two questions from each block. On the Interview sheet, write short notes under "Key things the student said": what they said, and how they said it.

Block	Main question	Easier	Stretch
Warm-up	Tell me a little about yourself.	What is your name? How old are you? Where do you live?	What would your friends say about you?
	How did you travel here today?	Did you come by car?	What do you like or dislike about your city?
School and learning	Tell me about your school now.	Do you like your school? What is your favourite subject?	What is the biggest difference you expect between your school and ours?
	Which subject do you find hardest? What do you do when work is difficult?	Is maths easy or hard for you?	Tell me about a time you kept going when something was hard.
	How do you learn English now?	Do you have English lessons? Do you read in English?	What helps you most when you learn new words?
	How do you feel about learning all your subjects in English?	Are you worried, excited, or both?	What will be hardest, and how will you deal with it?
Interests	What do you enjoy doing outside school?	Do you like sport, music or art?	What have you achieved in it that you are proud of?
	Tell me about a book, film or game you enjoyed.	Do you like reading? What kind of books?	Why did it stay in your mind?
	Do you take part in any clubs, competitions, volunteering or service?	Do you help at home or in your community?	What did you learn from it?
Friends and wellbeing	Who do you spend time with at school?	Do you have good friends?	How do you help a friend who is having a bad day?

Block	Main question	Easier	Stretch
	How do you relax when you feel tired or stressed?	What makes you happy?	How do you balance study, activities and rest?
	How many classes or tutoring sessions do you have after school?	Do you have classes at the weekend?	How do you feel about how busy you are?
Future plans and aspirations	What would you like to do in the future?	Do you have a dream job?	What steps would get you there?
	Where would you like to study after school, and what would you study?	China or another country?	Why does that place or subject interest you?
	Why do you want to join the international programme? Whose idea was it?	Is it your idea or your parents' idea?	What do you hope it will give you that your school now does not?
	What kind of person do you want to be at our school?	Do you want to join clubs?	What could you give to our school community?
Values (choose one)	A classmate asks to copy your homework. What do you do?	Is it OK to copy homework?	Why does honesty matter in learning?
	A new student is sitting alone at lunch. What do you do?	Would you talk to them?	Why might someone find it hard to join a group?
Opinion (to hear extended speaking)	Should students have homework every day? Why, or why not?	Do you like homework?	What would be a better system? Give an example.
	Should phones be allowed in school?	Do you use a phone at school now?	What are the strongest arguments on the other side?
Year 10 only	Which IGCSE subjects would you like to take, and why?	Which subjects do you like best?	How do they connect to your future plans?
	The IGCSE course takes two years. How will you manage starting a new course in English?	Will it be hard for you?	What support will you look for, and from whom?
Questions for us	What would you like to ask me about the school?	Do you have any questions?	

2. Speaking band

Choose the band that fits best, using the evidence from the whole interview, and tick it on the Interview sheet. Rate **listening in conversation** (how much of your English they understood) with the same letters. Pronunciation features of a speaker of Chinese do not lower the band if the student is easy to understand.

Band	What you hear
A New to English	Little or no spoken English, or single memorised words and phrases ("I am fine"). Relies on Chinese, gesture or silence. Understands very little unless supported.
B Early acquisition	Short answers and simple memorised sentences on familiar topics (family, school, likes). Frequent errors in word order, verbs and plurals. Needs the easier prompts. Understands slow, simple questions.
C Developing competence	Answers most main questions with connected sentences, using "because", "but", "so". Errors are frequent but meaning is usually clear. Vocabulary is everyday; searches for words on less familiar topics. Can give a short opinion with a reason.
D Competent	Speaks at length on most questions, explains and gives examples, handles the stretch prompts with some effort. Errors are occasional and rarely affect meaning. Some subject and abstract vocabulary.
E Fluent	Speaks as fluently and accurately as a fluent English speaker of the same age. Handles abstract and hypothetical questions easily, with a wide vocabulary.

3. Suitability

Rate each strand on the Interview sheet from what you saw and heard: **1** Concern, **2** Some concern, **3** Good, **4** Strong. Write the evidence: a short quotation or something you observed.

Strand	What strong looks like
Attitude to learning and resilience	Wants to learn, has a go, keeps going when work is hard, talks about effort and improvement
Curiosity and engagement	Asks questions, shows interest in ideas beyond the textbook, enjoys discussion
Social and emotional readiness	Relaxed or able to settle, makes eye contact (allowing for culture and shyness), talks about friends, manages feelings, ready for a change of school
Independence and self-management	Organises themselves, can describe how they study, manages time and activities, will ask for help
Values and conduct	Kind, honest and respectful in the interview and in the values question
Readiness for English-medium learning	Motivated to learn in English, willing to speak even with mistakes, has strategies for new words
Clarity and ownership of future plans	Has thought about what comes next, the plans are their own as well as the family's, understands why the international programme fits

Boarding readiness (only if the student will board): independence with daily routines, sleep, homesickness, experience of being away from home. Rate it on the Interview sheet in the same way.

4. Anything to follow up

Tick any that apply on the Interview sheet, and add a note:

- Possible special educational need or disability (for example reading, attention, speech, hearing, vision)
- Wellbeing (for example anxiety, low mood, very heavy workload, sleep)
- Safeguarding (passed to the Designated Safeguarding Lead the same day)
- Medical or dietary
- Mismatch between the student's wishes and the family's plans

Receiving homeroom teacher (optional). If the student's likely homeroom teacher meets them, they note first impressions and what the student would need in the first weeks (for example a buddy who speaks Chinese, a vocabulary book for each subject, a quiet check-in each morning) on the Interview sheet.

To finish. On the Interview sheet, write your comment for the final mark sheet (strengths, concerns, support), and sign and date it.